Pin and Replay, or Refuse: Exact Incremental Re-annotation Across Reference Database Releases

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Abstract

Biologists annotate genomes by searching their proteins against reference databases such as Pfam, which publish a new release every few weeks to months. Each release forces a full re-search, although most of the database has not changed: 86.6% of Pfam's entries were identical between releases 38.1 and 38.2. Reusing the old results is hard, because the search programs are fixed binaries whose printed statistics depend on the size of the whole database. We present TARE (Tool Annotation Reuse, Exact), a wrapper that reruns an unmodified program only on the entries that can matter, with the program's own database-size setting pinned to the new release, so that the program itself prints the numbers a full run would print. TARE then tests the replay by adding back entries it left out, and refuses, returning an ordinary full run, if any line changes. When it ships, every output line except comment headers is byte-identical to a full rerun; the assumption that makes this possible is tested on every update, not proved. By default TARE also reruns the program in full on 299 sampled records, so a hidden dependency that affects at least 1% of records ships with probability at most 5%.

On Pfam updates, TARE is [PENDING: W13 headline median]× faster than a full rerun (median of nine genomes on a dedicated server under the bounded-audit default; 95% CI [PENDING: W13 CI low]–[PENDING: W13 CI high]). Across 715,704 output lines from HMMER and Infernal, not one differed from a full run. TARE refused DIAMOND, whose first filter reads bytes of the neighboring database entry, and BLAST+, whose unpinned probe rows fit none of TARE's column rules.

1 Introduction

When a laboratory sequences a genome, it obtains thousands of protein sequences with no labels. To learn what each protein does, researchers compare it against *reference databases*: curated collections of known protein families, such as Pfam [16], UniProt [23], and InterPro [17]. A program such as HMMER [10] scores every protein against every family and reports the good matches, called *hits*. This step, called *annotation*, underlies much of modern biology, from comparative genomics to the sequence alignments used by structure predictors such as AlphaFold [12].

Reference databases keep improving. UniProt and InterPro publish a new version, called a *release*, roughly every eight weeks [17, 23], and Pfam published eight releases between May 2024 and June 2026 [19]. Each release adds and revises families, so annotations computed against an old release go out of date. The annotation programs keep no memory of earlier runs, so the only way to update is to compare every protein against the entire new database again. Most of that work recomputes answers that did not change: between Pfam 38.1 and 38.2, 86.6% of the 30,134 families were byte-for-byte identical (Figure 1). At scale this repeated cost shapes practice. NCBI re-annotates its RefSeq collection on a rolling schedule because redoing all of it at once "requires securing at once a significant amount of computing resources" [14], and JGI states that at over 65 billion genes "it is impossible to upgrade all genome and metagenome annotations to the latest version" [4].

Why reuse is hard. It might seem easy to search only the new and edited families and keep the old results for the rest. It is not, for three reasons. First, the results are *coupled*: the statistic HMMER prints for each hit, its E-value, is scaled by the total number of families in the database, much as a grade curved to class size changes for every student when new students enroll. Adding families therefore changes the printed numbers of hits on families that did not change. Rerunning HMMER on exactly the right families, without accounting for this, changes 9,083 of 9,094 output lines for one bacterial genome. Second, the programs are unmodified binaries maintained by others; we cannot change their code. Third, an approximately correct answer is not good enough: pipelines that track provenance must reproduce a full run exactly, because "pipeline differences can lead to annotation discrepancies" [4].

Existing tools fall short in two ways. General-purpose caches, such as build systems and workflow managers [6, 9, 15,

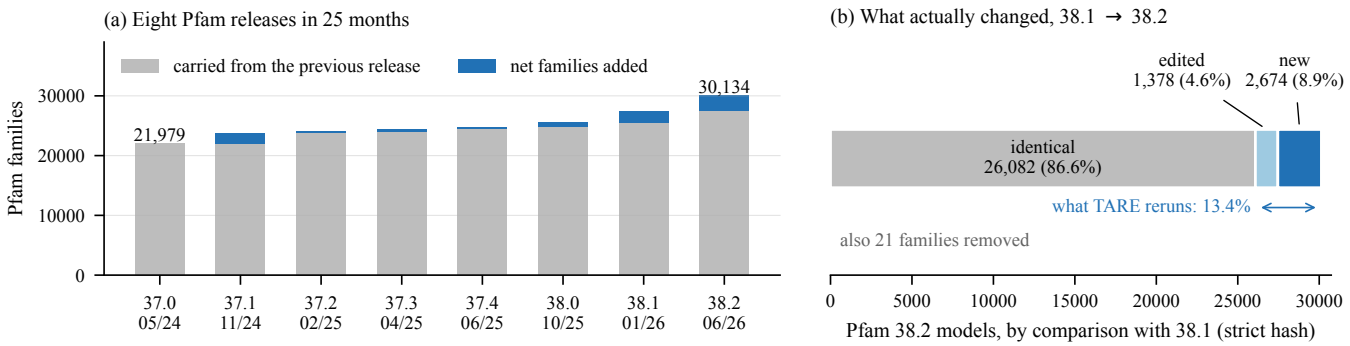


Figure 1: **Reference databases change often, but usually only in part.** (a) Pfam grew from 21,979 to 30,134 families over eight releases; blue segments show the net families each release added. (b) Comparing every model of Pfam 38.2 with 38.1 byte for byte: 86.6% are identical. Only 13.4% (new or edited) can produce new results, yet a conventional update recomputes 100%. Blue marks what TARE reruns. Panel (b) is the pair we time; Figure 6 measures the six neighboring releases the same way (median changed fraction 12.2%).

22, 25], remember whole commands keyed by the bytes they read. A new release changes the database file, so they rerun the search in full. Specialized incremental search tools such as iBLAST and iSeqSearch [8, 26] are written by hand for one program and adjust the printed numbers after the fact. Their output is approximate, and they cannot tell when their adjustment is wrong: in our experiment, only 1.3% of the rows that iSeqSearch shared with a full run were byte-identical, and it reported 133 hits to sequences that the new release had deleted. *How can we reuse earlier annotations across a database release, without modifying the programs, and either return exactly what a full rerun would print or knowingly fall back to one?*

The key idea in plain terms

In the programs we studied, entries in the database influence each other's printed results through only a few global numbers, chiefly the database size, and the programs already accept those numbers as settings. If we tell the program the new release's size up front (*pin* it), it scores each family on its own merits. Then we can rerun it on a small subset of the database and it prints exactly what a full run would print, digit for digit, because the program, not our wrapper, computes every number. This is what *taring* a scale does: fix the baseline first, then weigh only what is new. When a program breaks this pattern, we try to detect it and fall back to a full run.

Pinning a global size is not new in itself. Parallel search tools split a database across machines and fix the database size so that every piece prints consistent E-values [7], and HMMER's `-Z` option exists partly for that purpose [10]. What is missing is a way to use it across releases, for a binary we do not control, without trusting that the binary has no other coupling. TARE supplies that: it finds which entries changed (Section 3), reruns each protein only against its few candidate families with the size pinned (Section 4.5), and before returning anything adds back entries it left out and refuses if any line changes (Section 4.6). Every refusal falls back to an ordinary full run, so users always receive the program's own output.

We evaluate TARE on four programs: two where it reproduces full runs exactly (HMMER and Infernal) and two it refuses: DIAMOND, whose results depend on database order, and BLAST+, whose unpinned probes fit none of TARE's column rules. On Infernal, updates ran about twice as fast as a full rerun; on genomes made of a few long DNA sequences, TARE skips two of its sampled checks and relies on the remaining two (Section 6.3). Our contributions are:

1. **Exact replay across releases with check-or-refuse.** Release-diff selection and candidate-only, batched, pinned replay that makes an unmodified program print byte-identical output, guarded by a probe-based gate, a fallback when replay cannot pay, and a check whose audit bounds the chance of shipping a wrong update (Section 4).
2. **A root cause for a refusal.** Investigating a failure of our first check revealed why DIAMOND cannot be replayed exactly: its first filter reads bytes belonging to the neighboring database entry, so its results depend on database order (Section 6.4).
3. **A pre-registered evaluation.** Exactness over 715,704 output lines, speedups with their run-to-run variation, known-bad controls that must refuse, and comparisons with general-purpose caches and approximate incremental search, from experiments whose design and pass/fail rules were committed before they ran (Section 6).

2 Background

2.1 How Annotation Works

An annotation program takes two inputs: a set of *records*, such as the thousands of proteins of a bacterial genome, and a *reference* of *entries*, such as Pfam's 30,134 protein fam-

Table 1: Terms used in this paper.

Term	Meaning
Record	One query item, here one protein (or one DNA sequence for Infernal).
Reference	The database searched against, here Pfam or Rfam; a file of *entries*.
Entry	One family model in the reference (a profile HMM in Pfam).
Release	A new version of the reference.
Hit / row	A reported record–entry match; one line of the output table.
E-value	How many matches this good would be expected by chance in the whole database; scaled by the database size Z.
Stock run	Running the unmodified program on everything, the result we must reproduce.
Pin	Fixing a global setting (e.g., Z) to the new release's value.
Replay	Rerunning the unmodified program on a subset of the reference.

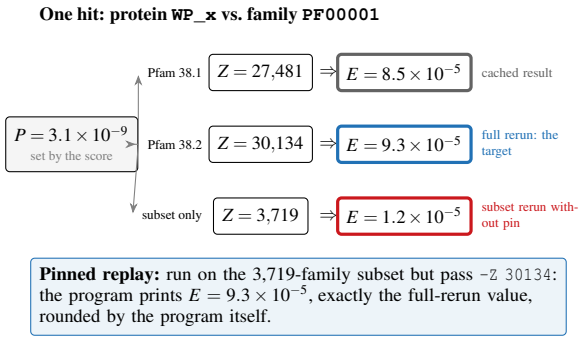


Figure 2: **Why old results cannot simply be reused.** An E-value is a probability P (fixed by the score) times the database size Z. The same hit prints a different E-value in each release, and a different one again if the program is rerun on a subset. Pinning Z makes the subset run print the full-run value. (Illustrative P; Z values are Pfam 38.1, 38.2, and one proteome's candidate subset.)

ilies (Table 1). Each Pfam family is stored as a statistical profile, a profile hidden Markov model, that summarizes what members of that family look like. HMMER's `hmmscan` compares every protein with every family, computes a score, and writes one line per reported hit, containing the names of the protein and family, the score, and an E-value. The E-value estimates how many equally good matches would occur by chance in a database of this size, and HMMER computes it as a probability multiplied by Z, the number of families in the database [10]. With Pfam's curated per-family score thresholds (the `--cut_ga` option), whether a hit is reported depends only on its score against that family's threshold [16].

2.2 Why Naive Reuse Fails

Suppose a laboratory annotated a genome with Pfam 38.1 and wants Pfam 38.2 results. The obvious shortcut is to search only the 4,052 families that are new or edited and keep the cached lines for the other 26,082. Nearly every kept line is then wrong, because its E-value was multiplied by 38.1's Z (27,481) instead of 38.2's (30,134) (Figure 2). Rerunning HMMER on exactly the right families does not help either, because the program then uses the subset's size as Z: on one genome, such a rerun differed from a full run on 9,083 of 9,094 lines, and the other 11 lines matched. Multiplying the cached E-values by $Z_{\text{new}}/Z_{\text{old}}$ gets closer but still fails, because printed numbers are rounded, and the rounding of a rescaled number differs from the program's rounding of its own internal value.

3 Problem Model

The effect of a release travels along a chain: a release changes some entries, and changed entries change some output lines. The goal is to produce every line of the new full run while running the program on as little as possible. We make this precise.

Definition 1 (Release)**.** A reference R is a list of entries in file order. Each entry has a name and a *strict hash* $h(e)$ of the content that affects scoring. A new release R' splits into *stable* entries $S = \{e \in R' : h(e) \in h(R)\}$ and *changed* entries $\Delta = R' \setminus S$.

Definition 2 (Exact re-annotation)**.** Let $f(Q,R)$ be the program's output on records Q and reference R, and $\text{body}(\cdot)$ the output with comment lines removed. Given $f(Q,R)$ and R', an exact re-annotation returns O with $\text{body}(O) = \text{body}(f(Q,R'))$ byte for byte, or refuses and returns a full run $f(Q,R')$.

Definition 3 (Coupling)**.** A program is *coupled* across entries if the line for record q and entry e can depend on entries other than e. We distinguish four forms: a *normalizer*, a global number computed from the whole reference, such as Z; a *side file*, an extra input file that lists entry names; an *entry group*, a set of entries whose hits compete, such as Rfam's clans; and *neighbor coupling*, where the program reads bytes of the entries next to e in the file.

Definition 4 (Entry locality under a pin)**.** A program is *entry-local under pin* π if, for every record q and every subset $U \subseteq R'$ that contains all entries reported for q in the full run, running it on $(\{q\}, U)$ with its normalizers set to $\pi(R')$ prints exactly q's lines from the full run.

Entry locality is what makes exact replay possible. It is a property of the program and its options, not something TARE proves; TARE tests it before and during every replay and refuses when a test fails. We assume the program is

deterministic for fixed options and thread count, and that every input it reads is named on its command line. TARE treats the program as a black box at run time and never reads its source code. We, the authors, did read the source code of HMMER, Infernal, and DIAMOND, to design experiments and to explain their outcomes; none of that knowledge is built into TARE.

4 Design

TARE updates a cached annotation in six stages (Figure 3). The first three decide *whether* exact replay is possible and *how*; the last three perform it and check it. Any failed decision or check leads to a full stock run.

4.1 Stage 1: Entry Diff

TARE splits both releases into entries and computes a *strict hash* of each: SHA-256 over the entry's full text, including its name, accession, description, length, Pfam's curated thresholds (GA, TC, NC), and every model line, after dropping only lines tagged DATE (build date), BM and SM (the commands that built and calibrated the model), or COM (comments). A renamed or re-thresholded family therefore counts as changed. Entries of the new release whose hash appears in the old one are stable; all others are changed. A cache keyed on the whole database file would miss on every entry after a release; a cache keyed on entry hashes keeps every stable entry, 86.6% of Pfam for 38.1→38.2.

4.2 Stage 2: Contract Inference

TARE must learn how the program's output depends on the reference without reading the program's code. It runs the program on a sample of records three times: against the whole reference, and against each half of it. It then lines up the output lines of the three runs by record and entry name.

Does the output split cleanly? If every line of the whole run appears in exactly one half-run, the output *decomposes* over entries: each line comes from one entry. If the whole run reports a line that neither half reports, entries interact in ways TARE cannot replay, and it refuses. The opposite case, a half reporting a line the whole omits, happens when entries compete and suppress each other; TARE accepts it only when the user declares which entries compete (Section 4.3).

How does each number depend on the reference? For each numeric column, TARE tests a small fixed set of hypotheses: the column does not depend on the reference at all (*identity*), or it scales with the number of entries, their total length, or the number of hits per record. A hypothesis fits if rescaling every half-run value by the corresponding ratio reproduces the whole-run value within the printed precision. A column that fits no hypothesis causes refusal. Columns that are ranks or labels rather than measurements are recognized and left to the program to reprint.

The result, called a *contract*, records how the output splits and how each column depends on the reference. It is computed once per command and reused for every later release.

4.3 Stage 3: The Coupling Gate

The gate turns the contract into a decision. Users may add declarations, which are data, never program names.

Size dependence → pin. If a column scales with the reference size, TARE needs a program option that sets that size. Users declare it (`--pin '-Z {entry_count}'`), and every experiment in this paper used a declared pin. TARE can also search for one, by reading the program's help text and trying each numeric option until one moves the column by exactly the predicted ratio; we tried this search only on HMMER and DIAMOND, and we have not evaluated its risks, such as an option like a random seed moving a column by coincidence. With the option set to the new release's value, the program prints on a subset the numbers it would print on the whole.

No size dependence → no pin. If every column fits identity, TARE replays without a pin. This is the case for Infernal under Rfam's recommended command, which derives its search size from the query sequence instead.

Side files and competing entries. Rfam's recommended command passes a "clan" file listing families that compete. On a subset, TARE rewrites that file to the families present, because the program rejects names it cannot find. If any member of a declared group changes, TARE re-searches the whole group, because a change to one member can reveal a hit of another that the cache never recorded.

The gate applies three rules in order and stops at the first that fires:

$$D = \begin{cases} \text{REFUSE} & \text{no contract} & \text{(R1)} \\ \text{REFUSE_PIN} & \text{size-dependent, no pin} & \text{(R2)} \\ \text{REFUSE_PIN} & \text{in-situ check fails} & \text{(R3)} \\ \text{AUTHORIZE} & \text{otherwise} & \end{cases} \quad (1)$$

R1 fires when the output does not split or a column fits no hypothesis. R2 fires when a column depends on the database size and no pin is available; TARE never guesses. R3 replays the probe sample against its own hits with the pin set and requires every byte to match the whole run. Every refusal runs the program in full; REFUSE_PIN differs from REFUSE only in what it reports: the output does decompose, so declaring a working pin could enable replay. Before replaying, the gate also falls back to a full run when f_Δ, the changed fraction of the reference, exceeds the break-even point $(1-c)/a$ of the cost model (Section 4.7); with no timing history it uses 0.80.

4.4 Stage 4: Selection

Changed entries may produce hits the cache has never seen. TARE runs the program on all records against the changed

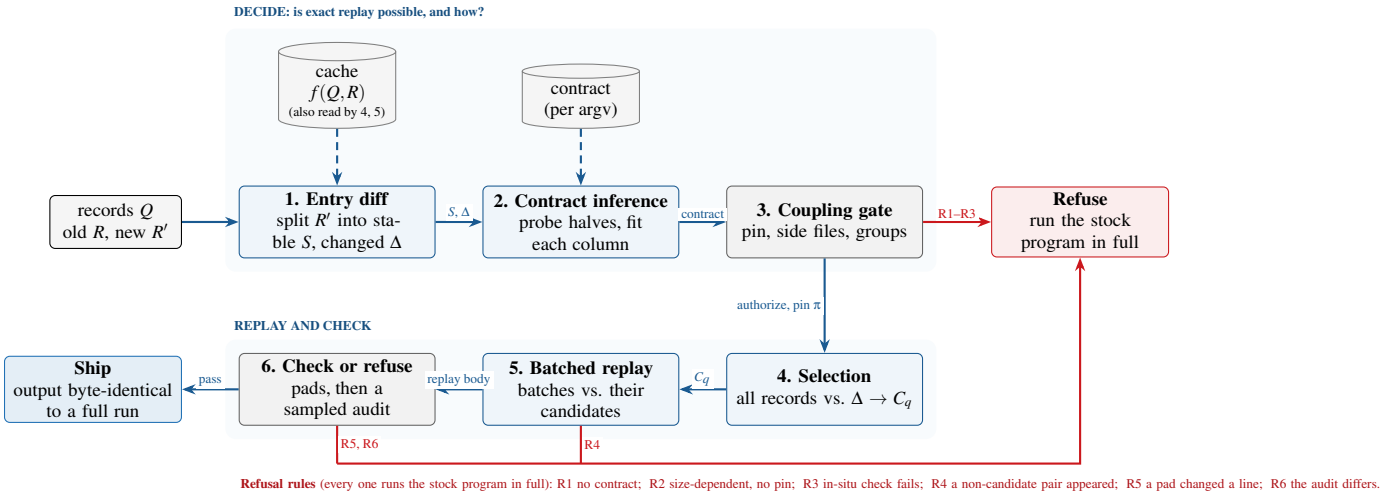


Figure 3: **How TARE updates an annotation.** Blue boxes do work; gray boxes are decision points. The top row decides whether the program's coupling can be neutralized; the bottom row reruns the unmodified program on candidates only and checks the result. Dashed arrows read stored state. Every refusal (red) leads to a full stock run, so a user always receives the program's own output.

entries Δ alone, with the pin set. A record's *candidates* are its cached hits on stable entries plus its new hits:

$$C_q = \{e \in S : (q,e) \in f(Q,R)\} \cup \{e : (q,e) \in f_\pi(Q,\Delta)\}. \quad (2)$$

Selection compares every record with every changed entry, so its cost is proportional to the changed fraction of the reference. It is the one cost TARE cannot avoid (Section 4.7).

4.5 Stage 5: Batched Exact Replay

Cached lines cannot be returned as they are, because their numbers were computed for the old release. TARE instead reruns the program on the candidates with the pin set, and the program prints the new numbers itself. Rerunning every protein against all candidates of all proteins would waste work: on one genome, the proteins' candidates together cover 3,719 families, but the mean protein has two. TARE therefore groups proteins into batches, runs each batch against only its own proteins' candidates, and stitches the outputs back together in the original order. It chooses the grouping that minimizes

$$T_{\text{replay}} = \alpha k + \beta \sum_b |U_b| + \gamma \sum_b |B_b|\,|U_b|, \quad (3)$$

where k is the number of batches, $|B_b|$ and $|U_b|$ the proteins and families in batch b, α the cost of starting the program, β the cost per family of preparing a sub-database, and γ the cost of one protein–family comparison. Stitching is safe for HMMER because, in its source code, each protein's output block depends only on that protein's own hits, including the column widths and the per-protein statistics. As a tripwire, if a replay ever reports a protein–family pair outside the candidates, TARE refuses (R4), because a full run could contain pairs the cache never saw.

4.6 Stage 6: Check or Refuse

The replay assumes the program is entry-local. The check tries to prove that assumption wrong on the actual run. It reruns the replay with *pads*, families that were deliberately left out, added back to the subset. If the program is entry-local, pads change nothing: no candidate line changes and no pad family is reported. If anything changes, the replay depended on what it left out, and TARE refuses (R5).

TARE uses two kinds of pads. The *neighbor pad* adds, for every replayed protein, the families that sit next to its candidates in the database file; it catches neighbor coupling by construction, the failure we found in DIAMOND (Section 6.4). *Random pads* add three random samples of left-out families, each as large as the candidate set, for a fixed sample of $s = 50$ proteins. They test for dependencies of unknown form. If an unknown dependency affects k of n proteins and a random pad includes the responsible family with probability q, the check misses it with probability approximately

$$P_{\text{miss}} \approx h + (1-h)(1-q)^3, \qquad h = \binom{n-k}{s} \Big/ \binom{n}{s}, \quad (4)$$

where h is the chance that the protein sample contains no affected protein. The approximation treats each pad as a single detection event; when several affected proteins fall in the sample, each pad has more chances to detect, so the true miss probability is lower. The neighbor pad needs no such formula: it contains every candidate's file-order neighbor by

construction. The check is a test, not a proof. As a final safeguard, an audit reruns the stock program on a random sample of s proteins and refuses if any line differs (R6). By default $s = \lceil \ln \varepsilon / \ln(1-\kappa) \rceil = 299$ for $\varepsilon = 0.05$ and $\kappa = 0.01$, capped at the record count: if at least a fraction κ of the records is affected, the audit misses all of them with probability at most ε. This is the classical zero-defect audit sample, not a new bound. The measured runs in Section 6 that predate it used an earlier audit, each record included with probability 0.02 and at least 20 in total. An optional first-use mode instead compares the first two updates of a new program with a full run.

4.7 Cost Model

Let T_{stock} be the time of a full run on the new release and $f_\Delta = |\Delta|/|R'|$ the fraction of entries that changed. TARE's update time is approximately

$$T_{TARE} \approx a f_\Delta T_{\text{stock}} + c\, T_{\text{stock}}, \tag{5}$$

where the first term is selection (a is near one if the program's time grows linearly with database size) and c collects every other cost (replay, check, audit, parsing) as a fraction of a stock run. The speedup $1/(af_\Delta + c)$ can never exceed $1/f_\Delta$, and even for a tiny release it cannot exceed $1/c$. The first run also fills the cache, which costs a full run plus the contract probes; with fill time F and update time U, TARE becomes cheaper than repeated full runs after $n \geq (F - T_{\text{stock}})/(T_{\text{stock}} - U)$ releases.

5 Implementation

TARE's core is 12,555 lines of Python, with 358 test functions. Its core contains no program names: small parsers read profile databases, covariance-model databases, FASTA files, and tabular outputs, and users declare pins, side files, groups, and reporting thresholds as data. The cache is a SQLite file keyed by entry hash and record. A typical invocation wraps the normal command shown below. The cache is namespaced by a hash of the command line with the reference path removed, so changing any option, including the thread count, starts a new cache and a new contract. This is conservative: repeated stock runs were byte-identical in every timed experiment. The namespace also includes a SHA-256 of the program binary, so upgrading a program in place starts a new cache.

```
tare run --strategy reference --pin '-Z {entry_count}' \
  --cache cache.sqlite -- hmmscan --cut_ga --noali --cpu 4 \
  --tblout {output:tblout} --domtblout {output:domtblout} \
  {reference} {input}
```

6 Evaluation

We ask four questions. **Q1:** Is TARE's output identical to a full run? **Q2:** How much faster is an update, and does the cost model predict it? **Q3:** Does TARE refuse when replay would be wrong? **Q4:** How does it compare with existing tools?

Method. Every experiment followed the same protocol, designed so that a failure means the method failed rather than that the test was blind. We first read the program's source for behaviors that could make a comparison fail for unrelated reasons, then ran a pilot on separate data, then committed the design and pass/fail rules to version control before the measured run. Each test included a case that must pass and a case that must fail, and a minimum number of output lines below which a result counts as inconclusive. Measured runs used genomes drawn by a fixed random seed and never used before. One rule changed after its pre-registration, during a measured run; we disclosed the change and reran every control (Section 6.4).

Setup. HMMER 3.4 (`hmmscan`) with Pfam 38.1 and 38.2; Infernal 1.1.5 (`cmscan`) with Rfam 15.0 and 15.1; DIAMOND 2.2.5 and BLAST+ 2.14.1 with Swiss-Prot 2026_01 and 2026_03; queries are bacterial genomes from NCBI RefSeq. Server timings use a dedicated AMD EPYC 7542 node; laptop timings use an Apple laptop shared with other work and are indicative only.

6.1 Metrics

Exactness. A run is EXACT if its body lines equal the stock run's as byte sequences; otherwise we count and classify the differing lines. Over N compared lines with none differing, the one-sided 95% Clopper–Pearson upper bound on the per-line error rate is

$$p_{\text{up}} = 1 - 0.05^{1/N}. \tag{6}$$

Lines of one run share a pin and a reference, so they are not independent and the bound is descriptive, not a guarantee. **Speedup.** For genome g with r alternating runs per arm, S_g is the median stock wall time divided by the median TARE wall time, both measured around the whole process. Across genomes we report the median of S_g with a 95% percentile bootstrap interval, the geometric mean, and the range. Differing lines are classified as whitespace-only, value-only, missing, extra, or reordered. Safety outcomes are EXACT, SAFE-REFUSE, or UNSAFE (any UNSAFE fails the claim). Wall time T is monotonic elapsed time of one complete invocation excluding `hmmpress`. Baseline overhead uses paired $\rho = T^{\text{tool}}/T^{\text{stock}}$ with a 95% t-interval.

6.2 Q1: Is the Output Exact?

Across the eight experiments in Table 2, not one of 715,704 lines differed from the stock run, so by Equation (6) a per-line error rate above 4.2×10^{-6} would be unlikely to produce this result (one-sided 95%). Without the pin, nearly every line differed: 26,094 of 26,127 hit lines on three genomes ($d = 99.87\%$, Wilson 95% CI 99.82–99.91%) and all 534

Table 2: Exactness experiments. “Lines”: output lines compared byte for byte with a stock run on the new release (HMMER: hit plus domain table). “Differ”: lines that differed. “Unpinned”: the same replay without the pin. “Replay” runs the replay engine alone; “tool” runs TARE end to end, with batching and the check.

Experiment	Lines	Differ	Unpinned differ
HMMER replay, 300 proteins	1,079	0	534 of 534
HMMER replay, 3 genomes	51,406	0	26,094 of 26,127
HMMER tool, 2 genomes (laptop)	35,434	0	not run
HMMER tool, 9 genomes (server)	155,577	0	not run
HMMER tool, 48 diverse genomes	463,225	0	not run
Infernal replay, 10 genomes	4,217	0	no pin needed
Infernal tool, 1 family removed	459	0	no pin needed
Infernal tool, 10 new genomes	4,307	0	no pin needed
Total	715,704	0	

on 300 proteins. The pin is therefore necessary and, with `--cut_ga`, sufficient.

Diverse genomes and needless refusals. On 53 further genomes (14 archaea, 30 bacteria, 2 eukaryotes, and 7 metagenome-assembled genomes), TARE shipped 48 updates, all byte-identical, and produced no unsafe result. It refused the other 5 although their replays matched stock: 3 because two domain-table rows of one protein shared the key (protein, family, E-value), and 2 because a text column held some values that parse as numbers. The *Drosophila* proteome, with 96 proteins of more than 20 domains, was one of the latter; three further eukaryotes did not finish within 12 hours and one bacterial job crashed on a storage error, so neither is counted. The duplicate-key rule also refused one of the ten server genomes below. These refusals cost speed, not correctness. After the measured runs we fixed both rules: repeated keys are told apart by their order, and a column that is mostly text is passed through. All six needlessly refused HMMER genomes, including the server genome and *Drosophila*, then shipped byte-identical updates (a follow-up, not part of any locked draw).

Where exactness ends. When HMMER reports hits by E-value threshold instead of `--cut_ga`, the replay matched on 300 proteins but failed on 1,000, differing on 3 hit lines and 5 domain lines. Hits near the threshold move in or out of a protein’s list, which changes that protein’s statistics; this mode is not entry-local and we do not claim it. The early pass on 300 proteins is why we require a minimum number of lines before accepting any result.

A second program. Infernal, which searches RNA families, behaved as its source code predicted: under Rfam’s recommended command every numeric column fits identity, so no pin is needed. Replaying each genome’s hits was byte-identical on ten genomes (4,217 lines) with and without clan competition. In that command, overlapping hits of competing families are marked rather than deleted, so removing a family cannot reveal a hidden hit; removing the family `GlmZ_SraJ` from one genome’s reference was exact through the shipped tool (459 lines). With the non-default option `--oskip`, which deletes marked overlaps, the same removal was refused, because fourteen overlap marks depended on families that had no remaining line. Through the shipped tool on ten further genomes (Rfam 15.0→15.1, three alternating runs per arm), every one of the 60 updates was byte-identical to its paired stock run in both variants, with 4,307 body lines per variant against a pre-registered floor of 2,000.

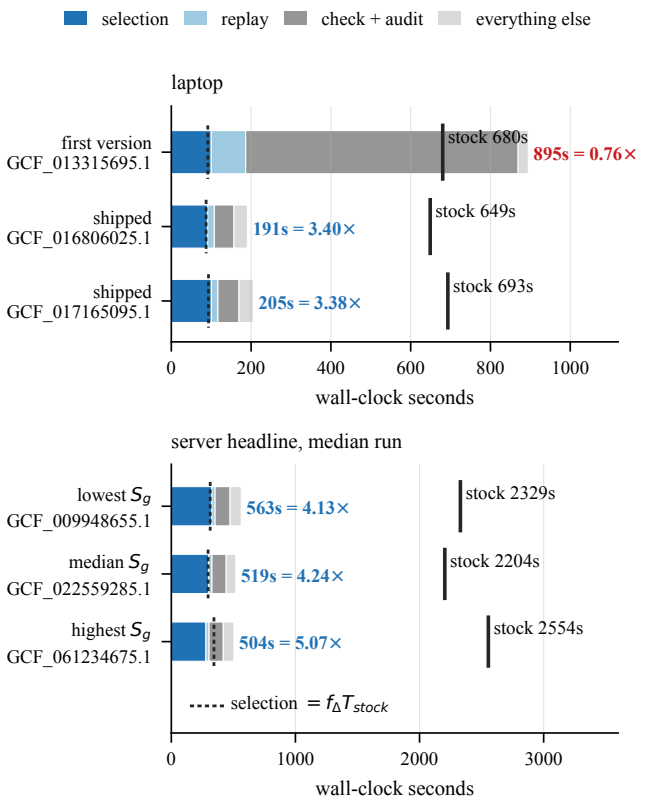


Figure 4: **Where the time goes.** Each bar is one update run, split into four stages; the black tick is a stock run on the same genome. Top (laptop, indicative): the first version, the median of three alternating runs, spent 668 s in its safety check and was slower than stock; batching and sampling (two fresh genomes) cut the update to under a third of a stock run. Bottom (server headline): the median-time update of the genomes with the lowest, median, and highest speedup. Dotted ticks: the cost model’s prediction for selection.

6.3 Q2: How Much Faster?

Figure 4 shows that the replay and check designs decide whether TARE is faster than a full run. Our first version replayed every protein against all candidates and checked

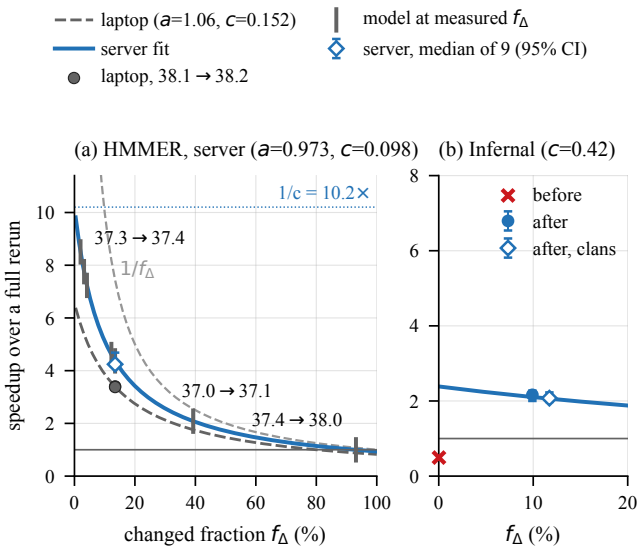


Figure 5: **The cost model across release sizes.** Speedup $1/(af_\Delta + c)$. (a) HMMER: the server fit from the nine headline genomes ($a = 0.973$, $c = 0.098$, solid) with their median and 95% CI (open diamond); the laptop fit ($a = 1.06$, $c = 0.152$, dashed) and its two updates (filled circles); the server model at the measured f_Δ of the other Pfam pairs (ticks); the bound $1/f_\Delta$ (dashed gray) and the server ceiling $1/c$ (dotted). (b) Infernal, with its own larger overhead: the first version (cross) and the shipped tool, medians of ten genomes with 95% bootstrap CIs.

the result with four more full-size replays. On the laptop, with three alternating runs per arm, it took a median of 895 s against a median stock time of 680 s ($S_g = 0.76\times$; CV 3.7% for TARE and 1.7% for stock); the check alone took a median of 668 s. Batching made the replay 5.2× cheaper and sampling made the check 17.9–19.3× cheaper (ratios of the first version's median check time to each shipped run's). On two fresh genomes of 4,583 and 5,019 proteins, TARE replayed in 107 and 111 batches and took 191 s and 205 s against stock runs of 649 s and 693 s: $S_g = 3.40\times$ and $3.38\times$ (geometric mean 3.39×), with byte-identical output. These are single runs on a shared machine, so we report no confidence interval for them; the server headline repeats each arm three times.

The cost model. With $f_\Delta = 0.134$, the selection term predicts 87 s and 93 s on those genomes; selection measured 91 s and 100 s, a relative error of 4.3% and 7.1%. The remaining costs, as a fraction of each stock run, average $c = 0.152$ (arithmetic mean of 0.153 and 0.151), so even a release that changed nothing could be at most 6.6× faster with today's overheads (Figure 5); the check, audit, and parsing are therefore the next targets. On the server, the same fit over the nine headline genomes gives $a = 0.973$ and $c = 0.098$, a ceiling of 10.2×, and predicts 4.37× at the timed release against the measured median of [PENDING: W13 headline median]×. The laptop cache fill took 871 s and 852 s (single runs), 1.2–1.3× a stock run, so TARE pays for itself from the first update (projected from these indicative times).

Other releases. Strict hashes of all seven consecutive Pfam pairs (Figure 6) put the changed fraction between 2.0% and 93.1%. At those measured values the server model predicts 4.6–8.5× for the four other pairs that changed at most 12.2%, 2.1× for 37.0→37.1 (39.3%), and 1.00× for 37.4→38.0, which rewrote 93.1% of Pfam's models. That release was a rebuild, not churn: 22,925 of its 22,965 edited models carry a new accession version, which `hmmscan` prints, and 19,976 have different model parameters. For such a release replay cannot pay, so the gate falls back to a full run (Section 4.3): with the server fit the break-even fraction is 0.93, and on a 40-model subset of this release ($f_\Delta = 0.975$) the default threshold fell back and the output matched stock. We have timed only the 38.1→38.2 pair. In a pilot on one genome, a cache filled at Pfam 37.3 and updated through 37.4, 38.0, 38.1, and 38.2 shipped at every step, and its 38.2 tables (9,635 hit and 9,378 domain lines) were byte-identical both to a full run and to a cache filled directly at 38.1, so cached results did not drift across releases; the timed version of that chain is running.

Server headline. On a dedicated node, across nine fresh genomes with three alternating stock and TARE runs each, the median of S_g is [PENDING: W13 headline median]× (95% percentile bootstrap CI [PENDING: W13 CI low]–[PENDING: W13 CI high]; geometric mean 4.39×; range 4.13–5.07×), and every update was byte-identical. The pre-registered draw had ten genomes: one refused at cache fill (the duplicate-key rule above) and is listed, not imputed, and three that hit the 4-hour job limit were rerun unchanged with 8 hours, a deviation we recorded before the rerun. The largest per-arm CV was 22.1% (flagged, not dropped, as pre-registered), and the pre-registered speedup prediction of 4.08× was within 19.4% of every genome's measured speedup. Filling the cache took a median 1.32× a stock run, so TARE pays for itself on the first update. These runs used the earlier audit; from their stage times, the bounded default adds about 4.3% of a stock run, and we are re-timing the nine genomes under it.

Infernal, with a reduced check. On Infernal, TARE ships with two of its four safety layers skipped on most inputs, and readers should weigh its Infernal speedups accordingly. The speedup did not at first carry over: only 457 of Rfam 15.1's 4,227 families (10.8%) changed, yet in the measured single-family removal the update took 666 s against a 328 s stock run, exact but 0.49×. A bacterial genome is one DNA sequence or a handful, so the audit's record sample and the random pads covered the entire genome, and an audit of a whole genome *is* a stock run. We therefore budget the audit and the random-pad sample by residues: when a single record holds more than half of the input's residues, those two layers are skipped and the output says so; the neighbor pad and

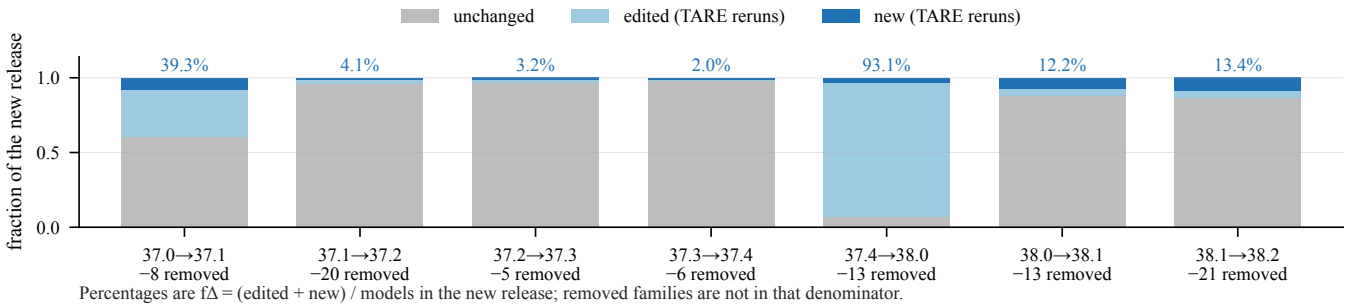


Figure 6: **Edits, not just new families, decide how much an update reruns.** Strict hashes of seven consecutive Pfam releases. Gray is unchanged. Light blue is edited and dark blue is new; both are what TARE reruns. The label is $f_\Delta = (\text{edited} + \text{new})/Z_{\text{new}}$. Pfam 37.4→38.0 reruns 93.1% of the new release: 22,965 edited and 822 new, with 1,758 unchanged, of 25,545. Pfam 38.1→38.2 reruns 13.4%: 1,378 edited and 2,674 new, with 26,082 unchanged, of 30,134, the same pair as Figure 1. The smallest change is 37.3→37.4, at 2.0%.

Table 3: Safety controls under the shipped check. Every case known to be wrong was refused, the correct case passed, and no run produced wrong output.

Control	Expected	Result
DIAMOND, 6 lines lost	refuse	REFUSE
DIAMOND, 22 lines differ	refuse	REFUSE
5% candidates dropped	refuse	REFUSE
HMMER genome (correct)	pass	pass, exact
DIAMOND, fresh sample	no wrong output	SAFE-REFUSE
BLAST+ boundary	refuse	REFUSE (R1)

the in-situ check always run. The change leaves HMMER's decisions and output byte-identical on a proteome, and every known-bad control still refused.

With this change, Infernal updates on ten fresh genomes ran a median $S_g = 2.16\times$ faster than stock without clan competition (95% bootstrap CI 2.00–2.28; geometric mean 2.07×; range 1.41–2.37) and 2.07× with it (CI 1.97–2.23; geometric mean 2.10×; range 1.96–2.33), against cost-model predictions of 2.08× and 2.05×. These are laptop timings with three alternating runs per arm: the largest per-arm CV was 29% (flagged, not dropped, as pre-registered), and the largest per-genome prediction error was 32%.

Infernal payback is slow. Cache fill was a median 4.45× stock (payback ≈6.4 updates); Infernal is worthwhile today mainly across several Rfam releases.

6.4 Q3: Does TARE Refuse When It Should?

A failure, and what it revealed. The check's design came from a failure. When we declared DIAMOND's database-size option (`--dbsize`) as a pin, the replay on 300 proteins lost 6 of 31,377 stock lines while every other line was byte-identical, and our first check, which used only random pads, passed it. Under our pre-registered rule, that was an UNSAFE result and invalidated that check. To find the cause, we added left-out entries back in halves until each missing line returned. Every one of the six lines was restored by exactly one entry: the candidate's neighbor in the database file. Figure 7 shows the mechanism in DIAMOND's source: its first filter reads bytes across the boundary into the preceding entry. DIAMOND's results therefore depend on the order of the database. A random pad contains one particular neighbor with probability 0.049, so three random pads miss it 86% of the time, which is why the first check passed.

Five other Swiss-Prot file orders on the same 2,000 queries changed 322 of 210,460 stock lines (173 missing, 148 extra, 1 value); 321 of those alignments sat inside the filter window of an entry boundary.

The shipped check. Adding the neighbor pad closed this gap (Table 3). On a fresh sample of 2,000 proteins, the replay differed from stock in 22 of 227,223 lines (20 missing, 2 extra), (0.0097% of lines), and the check failed on all five pads: a true SAFE-REFUSE. A second fresh DIAMOND sample was also refused. BLAST+ was refused earlier, at contract inference: one of 15,125 aligned lines has a percent identity (column 2) that matches no normalizer, so R1 fired. That line is a different alignment, measured below. In Table 3 the correct HMMER case passed; across all HMMER updates, 6 of 63 were refused needlessly (Section 6.2).

BLAST+ is still refused at contract inference (R1): unpinned probes print a different alignment on some rows, so percent identity fits no column rule. A pinned pilot was byte-identical to stock; we have not moved the probe under the pin, so BLAST+ does not ship.

Limits and the bounded audit. Random pads are weak against non-neighbor coupling (Equation (4), Figure 8): on a synthetic scorer (1,400 trials), file-wide coupling was always refused, but hidden or distant coupling missed on 741 of 800 trials. With the earlier audit, 489 of those 800 still shipped; with the bounded audit (s=299), where at least 1% of records were affected only 3 of 400 shipped (vs. 127 of 400 earlier),

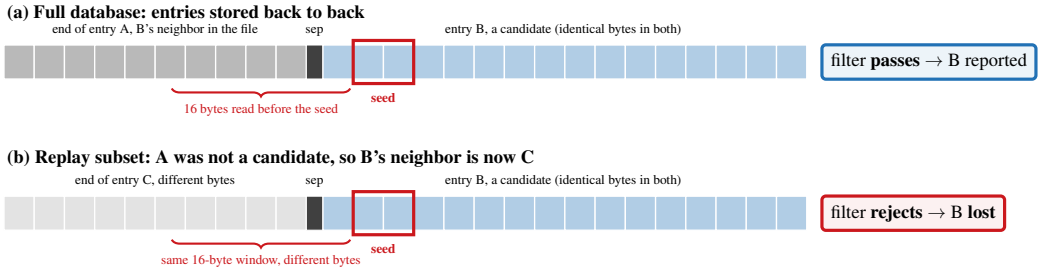


Figure 7: **Why DIAMOND cannot be replayed exactly.** DIAMOND stores database entries back to back, separated by a single byte. Its first filter examines a window of 16 bytes before and 32 after each short matching "seed" without stopping at the entry boundary (DIAMOND 2.2.5, `finger_print.h`). A seed near the start of entry B therefore reads the end of whichever entry precedes B. Removing that neighbor from the database changes the window and can drop B's hit. The neighbor pad adds A back, the file-order neighbor of every candidate; B's line then reappears, the check sees a line change, and TARE refuses (R5). Each of the six lines DIAMOND lost was restored by exactly one such neighbor.

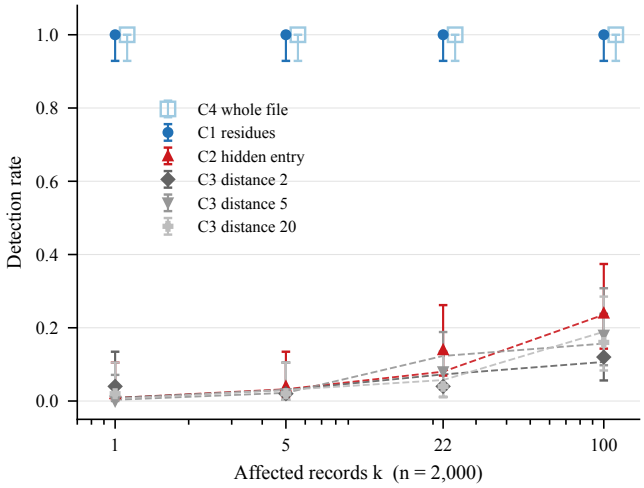


Figure 8: **The random pads miss coupling that is not a file-order neighbor.** Each point is the fraction of trials the check refused, with a Wilson 95% interval. Dashed curves are the random-pad formula (Equation (4)) for the forms it describes. File-wide coupling sits at the top of the plot; hidden and distant coupling does not. With no coupling (C0), 0 of 200 trials were refused. C4's squares are offset slightly right so both markers at 1.0 stay visible. The audit did not run in these trials.

matching the 5% bound, and all 200 clean trials shipped. The bounded audit is the default (6.4% of a stock run vs. 2.1% earlier). Guarantee: exact when entry-local; refuse file-wide and neighbor coupling; for hidden coupling, wrong updates ship with probability $\leq 5\%$ when $\geq 1\%$ of records are affected.

A disclosed mid-run rule change (candidate-vs-pad for dual-role entries) made the check more permissive; we reran every control and every known-bad case still refused. Option search finds size pins (e.g. HMMER `-Z`) but not reporting thresholds; a missing pin is R2, never a guess.

Table 4: General-purpose caches on HMMER: what each does on new input, and its first-run overhead against stock (mean, 95% t-interval).

System	New input	First-run overhead
Riker [6]	reruns	1.62× [1.53, 1.71]
INCR [25]	reruns	2.24× [2.06, 2.43]
ProcessCache [22]	reruns	not built (x86 only)
TARE	replays changed part	1.32× (server median)

6.5 Q4: Comparison with Existing Tools

General-purpose caches. Riker, INCR, and ProcessCache all re-executed HMMER on a new genome (Table 4): their unit is the command, so a release is outside their design. On n=4 paired runs (500 proteins, 30,134 families), Riker was 1.62× stock (95% CI 1.53–1.71) and INCR 2.24× (2.06–2.43). ProcessCache is x86-only in our build ([PENDING: W5x Table 4 rho]on the exclusive server when W5x lands).

Approximate incremental search. iSeqSearch's incremental DIAMOND [26] on 300 proteins (Swiss-Prot 2026_01→2026_03) matched only 407 of 31,377 shared lines byte-for-byte (1.30%) and retained 133 hits to deleted sequences (Figure 9); TARE refuses and returns stock.

7 Discussion

Three reviewer attacks. (1) *"This is just caching."* Command-keyed caches miss a release; TARE's grain is record × entry with a pin and a refuse path (Table 5). (2) *"The check is sampled, so it is not exact."* When TARE ships, every body line is byte-identical to stock; sampling bounds only the probability of shipping a *hidden* fault under the stated κ (Section 6.4). (3) *"One tool family."* HMMER and Infernal share lineage; DIAMOND and BLAST+ are refused from

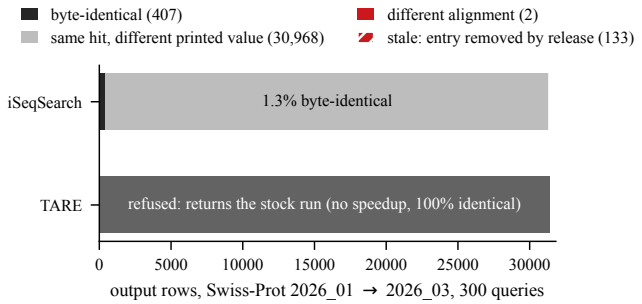


Figure 9: **Approximate versus exact.** Output of iSeqSearch's incremental DIAMOND after a Swiss-Prot update, compared line by line with a full run. Its numbers are close, but only 1.3% of lines match exactly and 133 lines report sequences the new release deleted. TARE refuses this program and returns the stock run, so it is exact but no faster; we did not time iSeqSearch.

other codebases, and pfscanV3 is supporting evidence only (Section 7).

Threats to validity. *Generality:* the two programs TARE replays exactly, HMMER and Infernal, come from one research group and share code, so they may share the property that makes replay work; the two refused programs come from other groups. We therefore claim that the method works for programs whose coupling lies in settings they expose, and that it detects when coupling lies elsewhere; we do not claim it works for most search programs. BLAST+ is still refused (Section 6.4). A program from an unrelated codebase, SIB's PROSITE scanner `pfscanV3`, ships with no pin: across two draws, 26 of 30 genomes shipped byte-identical updates with no differing line and none unsafe, and the other 4 fell just below the per-genome power floor. Both draws therefore count as inconclusive under our rules, and we offer them as supporting evidence only. *Release choice:* Figure 6 measures seven consecutive Pfam pairs. The fraction that must be rerun ranges from 2.0% (37.3→37.4) to 93.1% (37.4→38.0). We have timed only 38.1→38.2, where that fraction is 13.4%. *Timing:* laptop numbers are indicative runs on a shared machine; the headline is measured on a dedicated node with alternating runs. *Check strength:* below the audit's 1% guarantee, hidden coupling can ship (Section 6.4).

Anticipated objections. *"An expert could write this in a few lines of shell: run the changed families with `-Z`, then rerun each protein's candidates."* For HMMER with `--cut_ga`, yes, and that script is TARE without its gate, check, and audit. Removing those stages from the measured laptop runs bounds what it would gain: the check and audit took 7.6% of a stock run, so the script would reach about 4.6× where TARE reached 3.4× (an estimate from the measured stages, not a separate run). What the script cannot do is notice when its assumptions fail: run on DIAMOND, the same script silently drops hits, which is the case TARE refuses. *"Why not just rescale the cached E-values?"* Rescaling reproduces the program's arithmetic but not its rounding, and it must be written for each program and column; pinning lets the program print its own numbers.

Rescaling cached E-values matched only 58.0% of 44,132 HMMER hit lines (Wilson 95% CI 57.5–58.5%); value-only mismatches remain. An expert shell script was byte-identical on the two HMMER genomes in Table 2, but on a 2,000-protein DIAMOND sample it silently dropped 68 of 227,223 stock lines. Server timing of that script is [PENDING: W12a TARE/expert ratio](PENDING until W12a lands). *"InterProScan already reuses precomputed results."* Its lookup is keyed by the protein sequence for a fixed database version. *"Use a faster or GPU search program."* Complementary: it shrinks T_{stock}, and TARE's savings apply on top when coupling can be pinned.

Deployment. The natural deployment is InterProScan [11] after a member-database update. Member databases that score each model against its own threshold, as Pfam does, should behave like our HMMER results; those that compare hits across models would need declared groups or would be refused. Pfam's own pipeline, `pfam_scan.pl`, adds clan competition after `hmmscan`; we evaluated clan competition only for Infernal, so that step is not covered by our HMMER results.

8 Related Work

What is new. Command-keyed caches (Riker, ProcessCache, INCR, Nextflow/Snakemake) [6,9,15,22,25] rerun when input bytes change, so a release invalidates everything; they are not release-aware memoization. iBLAST/iSeqSearch/GeStore [8, 18, 26] are release-aware but rescale or plugin-merge and are not byte-identical (Figure 9). mpiBLAST [7] contributes the pin; TARE adds candidate selection, batched replay, and check-or-refuse. Black-box splitters and IVM [1,2,13,21,24] do not split a size-coupled database argument of an unmodified binary. Probes borrow metamorphic testing [5,20], not a new testing method.

9 Conclusion

Reference databases change every few weeks to months, and the programs that search them start from scratch every time. We showed that for programs whose cross-entry coupling lies in settings they already expose, this is unnecessary: pinning those settings lets an unmodified program reprint, byte for byte, the output of a full run while searching only what changed, and a check that adds back left-out entries catches coupling the pin does not cover, as it did for DIAMOND, whose filter reads neighboring entries. With the audit sized to a stated bound, hidden coupling that reaches at least 1% of records ships with probability at most 5%. Every replayed line across HMMER and Infernal in Table 2 was identical

Table 5: Prior work on the problem of updating annotations after a database release. "Unmodified": runs the program as is. "Release-aware": reuses work when the database changes. "Identical": output equals a full run byte for byte. "Per-tool code": requires code or formulas written for each program. †TARE's pins, side files, groups, and reporting thresholds are declared as data on the command line; its core has no program-specific code.

System	Grain	Unmodified	Release-aware	Identical	Per-tool code	Limitation for this problem
Riker, ProcessCache, INCR [6, 22, 25]	command / chunk	yes	no	yes	no	a release reruns everything
Nextflow, Snakemake [9, 15]	task	yes	no	yes	no	task inputs change
iBLAST [8]	appended sequences	yes	growth only	rescaled	yes	BLAST-specific E-value formula
iSeqSearch [26]	appended sequences	yes	growth only	rescaled	yes	1.3% of lines identical; stale hits
GeStore [18]	plugin	yes	yes	rescaled	yes	administrator-written plugins
Precomputed lookups [3, 11]	query sequence	yes	no	yes	no	keyed by query, fixed release
KumQuat [21]	input stream	yes	no	yes	no	no database argument
IVM, self-adjusting [1, 2]	operator	no	yes	yes	n/a	computation must be rewritten
mpiBLAST [7]	database segment	yes	no	yes	yes	parallel search of one release
TARE	**record × entry**	**yes**	**yes**	**yes**	**no†**	**refuses programs with hidden coupling**

to a full rerun. Across seven Pfam releases the fraction that must be rerun ranges from 2.0% to 93.1%; we have timed the 13.4% pair at [PENDING: W13 headline median]× on a dedicated server (median of nine genomes). Next steps: the other releases in Figure 6, BLAST+ with its pin, cheaper Infernal fill, and InterProScan.

Availability

An anonymized artifact accompanies this submission: TARE, every pre-registration and addendum, the result files behind each number, and the scripts that regenerate every figure. The repository URL is omitted for double-blind review.

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